

AGRICULTURAL AND RURAL POLICY STUDIES

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College of Agriculture and Life Sciences

Agriculture is more than just farming; it is about food, energy, and conservation. Rural is more than just small towns; it is the linkages between cities, urban consumers, and the global economy. Our major prepares students to guide policy decisions impacting agriculture, the environment, and the well-being of rural communities. In short, our major is the people and policy side of agriculture. Students will learn about the social and policy dimensions of agriculture and about strategies to promote rural resiliency and community vitality. The major will train students to engage with diverse audiences to discuss controversial issues, to promote public-private partnerships, and to lead and manage policy programs. Our goal is to give students the tools to help rural people and places thrive in the 21st century.

Our curriculum is flexible to meet the interests and needs of each student. A specialization area outside the major is required. Internships, experiential learning, and study abroad are important parts of the major. Graduates work as policy and legislative advisors, agriculture and farmer relations specialists, government affairs specialists, public information and communications officers, extension educators, community and economic developers, and in agriculture.

Student Learning Outcomes

Students will develop the necessary skills to become effective leaders in agriculture-related companies, non-profit associations and organization, and state and local government agencies working on agriculture and rural issues. Specific learning outcomes include:

1. Making connections between agriculture, the environment, and rural communities.
2. Making linkages between local, national, and global agricultural systems.
3. Investigating how social, economic, and cultural systems affect decisions.
4. Analyzing information and recommending solutions to guide decisions.
5. Evaluating program and policy outcomes.
6. Communicating information and ideas to others to guide decisions.
7. Leading and managing policy programs.
8. Promoting civic engagement among diverse groups.

CURRICULUM IN AGRICULTURAL & RURAL POLICY STUDIES

Administered by the Department of Sociology (<https://catalog.iastate.edu/collegeofliberalartsandsciences/sociology/>)

Total Degree Requirement: 120 cr.

The major in Agricultural and Rural Policy Studies requires a minimum of 120 credits and a 2.00 minimum GPA. Only 65 credits from a two-year institution may apply, which may include up to 16 technical credits. Up to 9 P-NP credits of free electives can be applied toward the degree.

University Requirements:

ENGL 1500	Critical Thinking and Communication	3
ENGL 2500	Written, Oral, Visual, and Electronic Composition	3
ENGL 3020	Business Communication	3
or ENGL 3090	Proposal and Report Writing	
LIB 1600	Introduction to College Level Research	1
U.S. Cultures and Communities from approved list (Met by SOC 3500)		3
International Perspectives from approved list (Met by SOC 3480 or SOC 3820)		3
CALS Communication Proficiency Requirement: A grade of C or better in 6 cr. of composition (ENGL 1500, ENGL 2500, ENGL 3020, or ENGL 3090); and a C or better in speech fundamentals (COMST 2140 or AGEDS 3110)		
Total Credits		10-16

CALS Requirements:

Mathematics from approved list (MATH 1400, MATH 1430, MATH 1450, MATH 1500, MATH 1510, MATH 1600, or MATH 1650) ¹	3
STAT 1010 Principles of Statistics ¹	3-4
or STAT 1040 Introduction to Statistics	
Physical Sciences from approved list (MTEOR 2060, [CHEM 1630 & CHEM 1630L], GEOL 1010, [GEOL 1020 & GEOL 1020L]) ¹	5
BIOL 1010 Introductory Biology ²	3
or BIOL 2110 Principles of Biology I	
Life Sciences from approved list (Met by AGRON 1810) ²	3
Ethics from approved list (Met by SOC 3250)	3
Humanities from approved list ³	3
Social Sciences from approved list (Met by SOC 2300)	3
AGEDS 3110, COMST 2140, or SPCM 2120 ⁴	3
Total Credits	20-30

¹ Math, Statistics, and Physical Sciences approved list: <https://www.cals.iastate.edu/student-services/math-stat-phys> (<https://www.cals.iastate.edu/student-services/math-stat-phys/>)

² Life Sciences approved list: <https://www.cals.iastate.edu/student-services/life-science> (<https://www.cals.iastate.edu/student-services/life-science/>)

³ Humanities approved list: <https://www.cals.iastate.edu/student-services/humanities> (<https://www.cals.iastate.edu/student-services/humanities/>)

⁴ Communications Proficiency approved list: <https://www.cals.iastate.edu/content/communications-proficiency> (<https://www.cals.iastate.edu/content/communications-proficiency/>)

Major Requirements -- Agricultural and Rural Policy Studies Core

SOC 1100	Orientation to Agricultural and Rural Policy Studies	1
SOC 2300	Rural Society in Transition	3
SOC 2620	Data Discovery, Analytics, and Visualization in the Social Sciences	3
SOC 2640	Facilitation of Public Issues in Agriculture	3
SOC 3250	Agriculture in Transition	3
SOC 3480	Global Poverty, Resources and Sustainable Development	3
SOC 3500	Human Diversity in Agriculture and the Food System	3
SOC 3820	Environmental Sociology	3
SOC 4150	Agrifood Policy and Social Change	3
SOC 4330	Strategies for Rural Resiliency and Vitality	3
SOC 4440	Sociology of Food and Agricultural Systems	3
AGEDS 3150	Personal, Professional, and Entrepreneurial Leadership in Agriculture	3
or POLS 4750	Management in the Public Sector	
Total Credits		34

Major Requirements -- Social Science Foundation

AGEDS 4510	Agricultural Law	3
ECON 1010	Principles of Microeconomics	3
ECON 2350	Introduction to Agricultural Markets	3
POLS 2830, POLS 3350, POLS 3440, or another approved POLS course		3
Total Credits		12

Major Requirements -- Agricultural Science Foundation

AGRON 1800	Global Agriculture in a Changing World	3
AGRON 1810	Introduction to Crop Science	3
ANS 1140	Survey of the Animal Industry	2
FSHN 2420	The US Food System	3

or AGRON 342C World Food Issues: Past and Present

Total Credits **11**

Major Requirements -- Minor or Multiple Major

Minimum of 15 cr. in a declared minor (3 cr. must stand alone); or a declared multiple or secondary major

Total Credits **15**

Electives

Free electives, OR a second minor, OR multiple major requirements

Total Credits **18**

AGRICULTURAL AND RURAL POLICY STUDIES, B.S.

Freshman

Fall	Credits Spring	Credits
SOC 1100	1 SOC 2620	3
SOC 2300	3 ECON 2350	3
SOC 2640	3 AGRON 1810	3
ECON 1010	3 ENGL 2500	3
ANS 1140	2 LIB 1600	1
ENGL 1500	3 Mathematics	3
15		16

Sophomore

Fall	Credits Spring	Credits
SOC 3480	3 SOC 3250	3
SOC 3500	3 POLS 3350, 3440, or 2830	3
AGRON 1800	3 FSHN 2420 or AGRON 3420	3
BIOL 1010 or 2110	3 STAT 1010 or 1040	3-4
Physical Science	3 Physical Science	1
Physical Science	1 Humanities	3
16		16-17

Junior

Fall	Credits Spring	Credits
SOC 4440	3 SOC 3820	3
AGEDS 3150 or POLS 4750	3 SOC 4150	3
COMST 2140 or AGEDS 3110	3 ENGL 3020 or 3090	3
Minor	3 Minor	3
Minor	3 Minor	3
15		15

Senior

Fall	Credits Spring	Credits
SOC 4330	3 AGEDS 4510	3
Minor	3 Free Elective	3

Free Elective	3 Free Elective	3
Free Elective	3 Free Elective	3
Free Elective	3	
	15	12

GRADUATE STUDY

The department offers work for the degrees Master of Science and Doctor of Philosophy with majors in sociology and rural sociology and minor work for students majoring in other departments. For M.S. and Ph.D. departmental requirements, see Program of Graduate Study for Degrees in Sociology and Rural Sociology, available from the department office. The department offers concentrations in a number of areas, e.g., community studies and development; sociology of families, inequality, food systems, agriculture and environment; methodology; social change and development; criminology; the economy, organizations and work; and social psychology. The Department of Sociology does not offer a nonthesis master's program.

Graduates have a broad understanding of sociology, address complex societal problems, and communicate effectively with scientific colleagues and the general public in both formal and informal settings. They understand sociological theory, conduct research, and are prepared to educate college students and contribute to public policy. Although the department stipulates no language requirement for either the degree Master of Science or the degree Doctor of Philosophy, specifying competence in one or more languages may be desirable in some instances.

The department also participates in the interdepartmental program in interdepartmental majors in sustainable agriculture, transportation and water resources, and interdepartmental minors in gerontology (see Index).